

ANGEL ACTION · CARDIAC

Heart Attack

Heart attack signs include chest pain or pressure, often spreading to the jaw, arm or back. Call 000 immediately, sit the person down, loosen clothing and give 300 mg of aspirin if they are not allergic.

Recognise a heart attack

- Chest pain, pressure, tightness, heaviness or squeezing
- Pain spreading to the jaw, neck, arm, back or stomach
- Shortness of breath
- Nausea, sweating, dizziness, light-headedness
- Pale, clammy skin

Symptoms can be vague in women, the elderly and people with diabetes — when in doubt, call 000.

What to do

1. **Call 000.** Do not let the person drive themselves.
2. Help them sit down in a comfortable position (often half-sitting, knees bent).
3. Loosen tight clothing.
4. Give **300 mg of aspirin** (one adult tablet or 4 x 75–100 mg) to chew, unless they are allergic, bleeding heavily, or have been told not to take aspirin.
5. If they have prescribed angina medication (GTN spray or tablets), help them use it.
6. Reassure them and monitor closely.
7. If they become unresponsive and are not breathing normally, start **CPR** and attach an **AED** as soon as it arrives.

Heart attack vs cardiac arrest

A **heart attack** is a blocked artery — the person is usually conscious. A **cardiac arrest** is when the heart stops — the person collapses and is not breathing normally. Cardiac arrest needs immediate CPR and an AED.

*Adapted from **Australian First Aid 5th Edition**. Get the full guide and live CPR metronome at firstaidangel.org.*